One reason for the lack of staff and capacity was indeed under-funding, in part caused by a sense that the election would cost too much at a time when the government had limited resources for other urgent matters. On 17 March 2015, the UEC proposed a 5700.811 million kyat (US$5.4 million) budget to parliament for the cost of the 2015 election, to erect polling stations, produce ballots, hold receptions for volunteers at voting booths, and so on. One parliamentarian raised a question about the UEC's budget proposal, which was equivalent to the cost of building 126 Rural Health Centers (RHCs). Building RHCs was one of the Millenium Development Goals (MDGs) to be accomplished in 2015. The point was that holding a national election would cost a lot to the national budget that could be used elsewhere. The Hluttaw decided to record that motion.

In the lead-up to the election the UEC was criticized both by political parties and CSOs over the issuing of registered voters lists; the drafting of a Code of Conduct for the media, election observers, and CSOs; cancelling of the election in some constituencies (see Lidauer, this volume); and the way international election observers were allocated to different regions.

One of the issues that caught attention was advance votes, which had caused public concern in the 2010 general elections. In 2015 similar questions were raised about what would happen with the advance votes, but whereas the problem in 2010 was one of fraud, in 2015 it turned out for the most part to be one of capacity. When advance voting began in some Myanmar embassies abroad, especially in Singapore where hundreds of thousands of Myanmar citizens work, information was posted on social media about inconsistent voting procedures and ballots. It was a huge task for Myanmar embassies to arrange convenient advance voting due to their lack of prior experience and limited staff. Voters were confused and there were problems associated with the short time frame and lack of cooperation among government officials, the UEC, and staff at embassies.

The UEC's efforts to police the activities of campaigning political parties also attracted attention. With locals and the international community watching, the UEC needed to take a firm stand and act as an independent body, not as a partisan of one party or another. It issued warnings to parties about various activities. For example, it called on the United Nationalities Alliance to avoid supporting student protests over a new National Education Law in early 2015 (Hein Ko Soe 2015). It also warned the Mon National Party, which published a joint statement with the New Mon State Party, a group still in armed struggle against the central government (Lawi Weng